

HSE TOOLBOX TALK

WORKING NEAR OPEN EDGES

PURPOSE AND SCOPE

Open edges, floor openings, shafts and incomplete façades create fatal fall exposure. Verify surface strength and install fixed guardrails or covers where practicable. When personal fall arrest is used, verify anchorage, connection, clearance, swing-fall exposure and rescue together.

KEY HAZARDS

1



OPEN EDGE

2



FLOOR OPENING

3



UNCONTROLLED ACCESS

4



FALLING OBJECT

5



SWING FALL

6



WIND / ICE

7



ANCHOR FAILURE

8



SUSPENSION

CRITICAL VALUES TO VERIFY IN THE FIELD

1,8 m

OSHA construction fall-protection trigger

1,07 m

Typical top-rail height

22,2 kN

Anchorage strength per worker



REMEMBER - SERNEM

S

Stop and think

E

Evaluate the risk

R

Remove or reduce

N

Never assume

E

Ensure protection

M

Monitor and communicate

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STANDARDS AND FIELD REQUIREMENTS

OSHA Subpart M requires verification of surface integrity and collective protection first, followed by all fall-arrest criteria where a personal system is used.

OSHA 1926.501(a)

SURFACE STRENGTH

Employees may work only on walking and working surfaces verified to have adequate strength and structural integrity.

OSHA 1926.501(b)(1)

OPEN-EDGE PROTECTION

At unprotected edges 1.8 m or more above a lower level, provide guardrails, safety nets or personal fall arrest.

OSHA 1926.502(b)

GUARDRAIL CRITERIA

Install top rails, midrails, openings and strength to the standard; immediately control any temporarily removed section.

OSHA 1926.502(d)

FALL ARREST

Use a full-body harness, compatible connectors and approved anchorage; limit free fall and prevent contact with lower levels.

MINIMUM EVIDENCE BEFORE START

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Fall-protection plan | ☐ Edge and opening layout |
| ☐ Guardrail / cover inspection | ☐ Anchorage verification |
| ☐ Clearance calculation | ☐ Rescue plan |

SUPERVISOR DISCUSSION POINTS

- Who installs alternative protection if a guardrail is temporarily removed?
- What obstruction could be struck in a swing fall here?
- How quickly can rescue equipment reach the worker?

COLLECTIVE AND PERSONAL PROTECTION AT AN OPEN EDGE



Complete guardrail - Safe distance - Overhead lifeline - Controlled area

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CRITICAL CONTROL MEASURES (HIERARCHY OF CONTROLS)

1. WORK AWAY FROM THE EDGE

Plan work at ground level or away from the edge; route materials and access through the safe zone.
2. INSTALL COLLECTIVE PROTECTION

Prefer fixed guardrails, covers and barriers to personal systems; mark all openings.
3. RESTRICT AND ARREST FALLS

Use restraint or fall arrest with correct anchorage and calculated clearance.
4. MANAGE ACCESS AND RESCUE

Prevent unauthorized entry; provide supervision, communication and a task-specific rescue plan.

CRITICAL WARNING

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Once a guardrail is removed, the edge becomes an immediate fall hazard. Do not approach without alternative protection, and never connect a harness to improvised pipework, guardrails or equipment.

SITE CHECKLIST (BEFORE STARTING WORK)

- ☐ Surface strength verified

☐ Safe work boundary defined

☐ Anchorage and connections approved

☐ Area below and falling objects controlled

☐ Rescue plan and team ready

☐ Guardrails and covers complete

☐ Access limited to authorized personnel

☐ Fall clearance calculated

☐ Weather conditions suitable

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ATTENDANCE AND APPROVAL

Project / Site:

Date:

Presented by:

Work area:

No	Full Name	Company / Role	Signature
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			